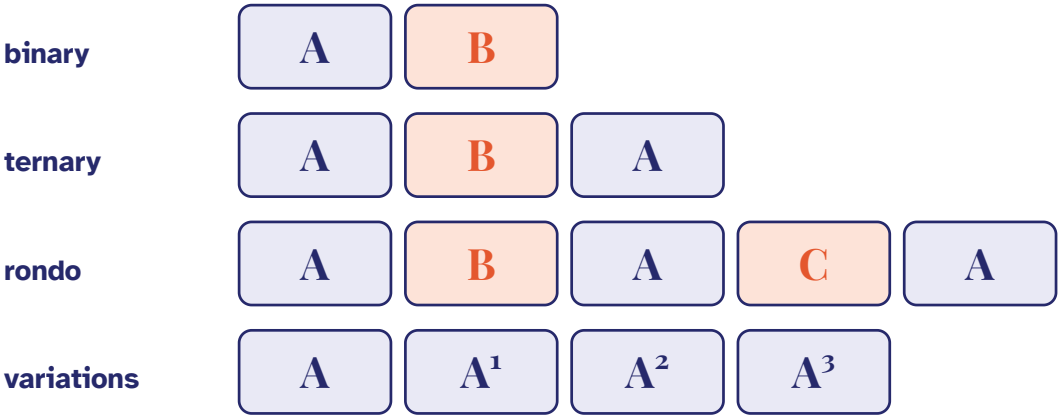
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5

Form

Form is the map of a whole piece: which sections come, in what order, and which come back. Letters name them: **A** for the first idea, **B** for the next new one, and so on.

THE SECRET

Same music, same letter. New music, next letter.



The map of a piece, in letters

FORM	LETTERS	SHAPE	YOU KNOW IT FROM
binary	A B	two halves, each often repeated	Baroque dances: minuets, gigues
ternary	A B A	out, away, and back	many short Romantic pieces
rondo	A B A C A	A keeps coming back between new ideas	Beethoven, Für Elise
theme and variations	A A^1 A^2 A^3	one tune, dressed differently each time	Mozart's variations on "Twinkle"
strophic	A A A	the same music for every verse	hymns, folk songs
verse and chorus	V C V C	the chorus words stay the same	pop songs

THE RULE

Same music, same letter. New music, the next letter. A little changed: add a small number (A^1).

LISTEN FOR IT

Petzold
Minuet in G (Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach; once thought to be Bach's)
binary: two halves, each repeated

Beethoven
Für Elise
rondo: A B A C A

Mozart
Twelve Variations on "Ah vous dirai-je, Maman"
theme and variations, on the tune of Twinkle

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Sonata form

The big first movements of sonatas and symphonies: an **exposition** (two themes, the second in a new key), a **development** (the themes taken apart and moved through keys), and a **recapitulation** (both themes again, now at home).

EXAMPLE 1

Which letter makes it ternary?



1. **A B** alone: two sections.
2. **Ternary** goes out, away and...?
3. **Which letter** fills the box?

A. A B is binary; A B **A** is ternary.

EXAMPLE 2

Which form?
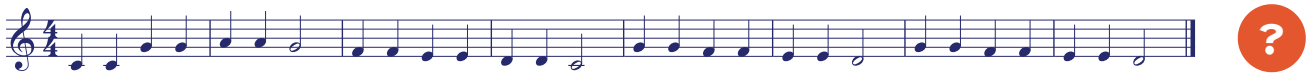


1. **Count the sections.**
2. **Which one keeps coming back?**
3. **What comes between?**

A returns between two new ideas: a **rondo**.

EXAMPLE 3

Map Twinkle



1. **Bars 1–4:** call them A.
2. **Bars 5–8:** new or the same?
3. **The last four bars** (not shown) repeat bars 1–4.

Bars 5–8 are new: B. Then A again: **A B A**, ternary.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



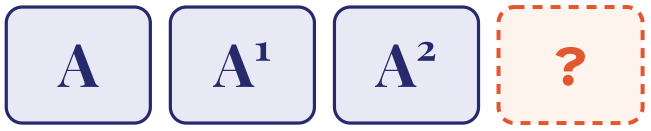
Map a piece you play.

Give every 4-bar phrase a letter. Same music, same letter. What form is it?

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

What comes next?



1. **A** is the theme.
2. **A¹ and A²**: the same tune, dressed differently.
3. **The next one** is called...?

A³: a third variation. Theme and variations keep one tune and change its clothes.

GAME

Name the form

1	2	3	4
A B	A B A	A B A C A	A A¹ A² A³

Name each map.

Answer: 1 binary · 2 ternary · 3 rondo · 4 theme and variations.

HOW TO

Learn a piece by its map

1. **Letter the sections** in pencil.
2. **Learn A first**: it comes back, so it pays twice.
3. **Then the new sections**, and practise the joins between them.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Für Elise



The famous opening tune is **A**. It is heard three times, with two new sections in between: a rondo.

Try it. Listen and raise your hand every time A returns.

THINK OF IT Form is the floor plan of a house: once you know the rooms, you never get lost in it.

TRAP

- × Giving every phrase a new letter: same music, same letter.
- × Counting a repeat as a new section: A played twice is still A.

SEE ALSO

Repeats and road signs p. 68 · Changing key p. 151

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Form